Openhearted, Not Unguarded

Building Healthy Connections in Recovery

Recovery depends on connection, trust, and vulnerability. Everyone deserves to feel welcome, respected, and safe participating in our fellowship.

Not everyone will treat others with the care they deserve. Harm can take many forms, from discrimination and unwanted attention to manipulation, harassment, and exploitation.

We can be openhearted without being unguarded.

Safety isn't only about responding when something goes wrong. It's also about building the connections, judgment, and resilience that help us navigate relationships without losing our connection to recovery.

Resilience isn't about closing ourselves off. It's developing the relationships and capacities that make vulnerability sustainable.

Four Principles for Navigating Relationships in Recovery

1. Build connections. Develop a broad support network so your recovery doesn't depend on any one relationship.

2. Practice discernment. Learn to recognize both genuine danger and unnecessary alarm, examine your assumptions, and choose how to respond.

3. Respect autonomy, yours and others'. Recognize that your needs and boundaries matter, as do everyone else's.

4. Seek support. Draw on others for perspective, help, and connection. Don't let difficult experiences become isolating experiences.

1. Build a Broad Support Network

Build connections with more than one person, at a pace that works for you. Get to know people in different parts of the fellowship, so your support doesn't depend on any one person or circle. You don't have to share everything with anyone.

A difficult or harmful experience with one person needn't become your whole experience of recovery.

2. Practice Discernment

Some of us have learned to see danger everywhere; others have learned to overlook danger, even when it’s right in front of us. Most of us do some of both.

Where you’re frequently alarmed, practice distinguishing discomfort from danger. Where you’ve learned to suppress discomfort, practice recognizing when something may be wrong even when everything seems fine.

Neither your feelings nor their absence tells the whole story. Notice your reactions, or lack of reactions, without automatically accepting or dismissing them.

Look at what's happening. Ask yourself: *What happened? What am I assuming it means? What do I need?*

Consider whether your boundaries are respected, and seek perspective from people you trust.

Putting the Principles into Practice

3. Respect Boundaries, Including Your Own

Vulnerability isn’t an invitation to romantic or sexual attention. You never owe anyone personal information, intimacy, or continued contact.

You can say no, change your mind, or disengage without owing anyone an explanation.

You can also ask for what you need, and others can be honest about what they can offer.

Notice what you're seeking from others. Are you considering the other person's wellbeing as well as your own? Your needs and desires are legitimate, but they don't obligate anyone else. Healthy connection respects everyone's freedom to choose.

Others have that same freedom. Respect their choices without demanding explanations or pressuring them to reconsider. You can acknowledge your own disappointment without assuming what their decision means about you.

Good intentions don't guarantee a welcome impact. Notice when your attention isn't welcomed or reciprocated, respect others' responses, and be willing to change course.

4. Reach Out and Speak Up

Whether something feels wrong or you simply want another perspective, talk it over with someone you trust, whether a friend, sponsor, or group trusted servant.

You don't need to be certain that anyone has done something wrong before seeking support.

You don't have to determine someone's motives before deciding to pause, decline, seek support, or leave.

Sometimes the next step is setting a boundary, sometimes it's disengaging, sometimes it's working through discomfort, and sometimes it's asking for help addressing harmful behavior.

As you learn more, you can change your understanding or choose a different response.

If someone crosses your boundaries, you are not alone, and you are not to blame for their behavior. You deserve support even if you didn't recognize the problem, found it hard to say no, or are still unsure what happened.

Staying connected to recovery doesn't require staying in a relationship or meeting that harms you.

You don't have to navigate difficult experiences alone. Reach out. Connection is part of recovery.

Safety and Our Primary Purpose

MA's Safety Card complements these principles with guidance for recognizing safety concerns, seeking support, and helping groups maintain safe, welcoming meetings.

MA Safety Card: MA12.org/safetycard

Guided by Traditions Three and Five, our goal isn’t to judge who’s worthy of recovery. It’s to foster a community where everyone has the opportunity to pursue it, even when some of us are still sick and suffering.

Everyone deserves a chance at recovery. Everyone deserves to feel safe seeking it.

An independent, member-created resource for navigating relationships in recovery. Not an official publication of Marijuana Anonymous.